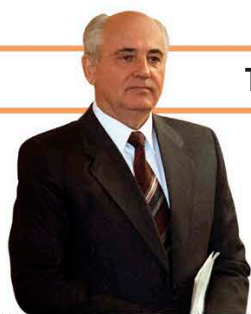


The collapse of the USSR

In 1985, the new Soviet leader Mikhail Gorbachev came to power in the USSR and began to introduce political and economic reforms. He rejected the Brezhnev Doctrine, which allowed the USSR to send in its army to other communist countries if their governments were threatened. The USSR withdrew its troops and support from Eastern Europe. Without that support, communist-led governments such as in Poland and Hungary were forced to hold free elections. The USSR itself collapsed in December 1991 and communist rule in Eastern Europe came to an end.



THE FALL OF THE EASTERN BLOC

1985

Mikhail Gorbachev begins to reform the USSR with policies of *glasnost* (openness) and *perestroika* (reconstruction) to modernize the struggling country.

MIKHAIL GORBACHEV

1989

Hungary opens its closed border with Austria, creating a route to western Europe. Thousands of East Germans use it to flee into West Germany. Without Soviet support, communist governments begin to fall across Eastern Europe.

1990

After the fall of the Berlin Wall, East and West Germany are reunited into one country. In 1991, the German parliament votes to make Berlin the capital of a united Germany. Free elections are held in all former communist countries, and democratic governments come to power by 1991.

1991

Gorbachev survives a coup planned by hard-line communists and he bans the Communist Party. Ukraine and other republics leave the USSR, which collapses at the end of the year as Gorbachev resigns.

FALL OF THE BERLIN WALL ►

In November 1989, a new communist leader in East Germany announced that the Berlin Wall would be opened to allow its citizens to visit West Berlin. Thousands of people poured through the openings, while demonstrators began to climb over the wall watched by nervous East German border guards. The symbol of a divided Europe was soon torn down and Germany was united.

